

Headstart
MENTORING

ROAD TO YOUR FIRST GRAD OFFER

IN AUSTRALIA



STAGE 3: QUALIFIERS



Based on:

- Conversations with 500+ students/grads
- 30+ offers secured across Tech/Business/Engineering

YOU ARE HERE

STAGE 3: QUALIFIERS



STAGE 2: CONNECTIONS			STAGE 3: QUALIFIERS			STAGE 4: FINAL BOSS	
JOBS APPLIED	50 - 200+		INTERVIEWS	Recorded Interviews: 3+ Screening Calls/Online Interviews: 3+ F2F Interviews: 0-2		INTERVIEWS	Screening Calls/Online Interviews: 5+ F2F Interviews: 2+
# OF PEOPLE HERE CURRENTLY	13,800 (10% of University Students in Australia [Students studying Biz/Tech/Engineer in their Last Year] are here now)		CONSTRAINTS	TO ADVANCE TO NEXT STAGE		CONSTRAINTS	TO ADVANCE TO NEXT STAGE
SCREENING CALLS/ONLINE INTERVIEWS	You don't know the difference between a screening call/online interview vs an In-person interview		INTERVIEWERS	You don't know the difference between: Hiring manager vs Recruiter/Talent Acquisition vs Recruitment Agency			
CONSTRAINTS	Interviews come inconsistently and only once every 3 weeks after 50+ applications	Have 1 screening call	CONSTRAINTS	You understand the difference of a screening call/online interview vs an In-person interview, and have progressed 2+ times to the next round from them		CONSTRAINTS	You understand the best principles you must do in group case studies
APPLICATION METHODS	Mainly Online Applications, through platforms like LinkedIn, Seek, Seekgrid, Indeed, Job Portal, Never through referral	Get 1 referral / intro you are applying to	CONSTRAINTS	You are able to cater your communication depending who you are talking to		CONSTRAINTS	You understand you must have a Unique Value Proposition / Unique and Relevant Stories / Personal Connection, on top of hard work and preparation, to maximise your chance.
CONSTRAINTS	Have tried reaching out to recruiters, but very rarely get a response or link to them	Reached out and had professionals, that a	CONSTRAINTS			CONSTRAINTS	
CONSTRAINTS	Currently only connected to peers from Uni who you don't even know (random connections)	Connected to 100+ industry. Attempted	CONSTRAINTS			CONSTRAINTS	

0. FOUNDATION

1. VISIBILITY

2. CONNECTIONS

3. QUALIFIERS

4. FINAL BOSS



STAGE 3: QUALIFIERS		
JOB'S APPLIED	50 - 200+	
INTERVIEWS	Recorded Interviews: 3+ Screening Calls/Online Interviews: 3+ F2F Interviews: 0-2	
# OF PEOPLE HERE CURRENTLY	28,800 (10% of International + Domestic students studying Business/Tech/Engineering in their Last Year are here now)	
CONSTRAINTS		TO ADVANCE TO NEXT STAGE
SCREENING CALLS/ONLINE INTERVIEWS	You don't know the difference between a screening call/online interview vs an In-person interview	You understand the difference of a screening call/online interview vs an In-person interview, and have progressed 2+ times to the next round from them
INTERVIEWERS	You don't know the difference between: Hiring manager vs Recruiter/Talent Acquisition vs Recruitment Agency	You are able to cater you communication depending who you are talking to

Think you are not a strong enough candidate? Head to ‘Appendix - Page 1’ to see if you have at least 3 out of 6 strong traits.

WHEN YOU ARE AT: “STAGE 3: QUALIFIERS”

The advice is based on:

- Conversations with 500+ students/grads
- 30+ offers secured by across Tech/Business/Engineering

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Welcome to Stage 3 - you are already in the top 30% of candidates, having secured 3+ screening calls, and possibly 1-2 face to face interviews. However, you are mostly rejected after the screening call, in 80% of the time and you want to understand why.

Your goal is simple: To understand how screening calls / online video interviews are different from in person interviews, and to understand how to stand out to increase your rate of progression from them.

HERE'S HOW YOU ARE LIKELY FEELING RIGHT NOW AND HOW THIS DOC HELPS



Confusion

You've managed to land screening calls consistently, but you get rejected most times



Clarity

You understand the key's of a successful screening call and the reason why you get rejected

Frustration

You work so hard to secure the screening calls, but you get rejected and don't get feedback



Motivation

Understanding what you can improve on to ace your next call

Jealousy

Some of your friends are starting to get offers



Still Jealous

But now you know how you can catchup

Anxious

Always checking your gmail notifications to see interview results



Calmness

You finish a screening call knowing you tried your best.



WHAT THIS RESOURCE COVERS

INTRODUCTION OF 2 TOTALLY DIFFERENT TYPES OF SCREENING CALLS

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN SCREENING CALL/ONLINE INTERVIEW VS IN PERSON INTERVIEW

INTRODUCTION OF 2 TOTALLY DIFFERENT TYPES OF SCREENING CALLS

1. RECRUITER / HR CALL INSIDE THE HIRING COMPANY



- They are not going to be your manager, they are HR doing the screening
- They don't exactly know the details of your role since they are just in HR
- Since they may not understand the technical things of the role, they'd just jot notes from the call
- What are discussed in those calls 📌

A self-introduction

Why do you want to work for the company?

What about the role interests you?

They seldom ask behavioural questions.

They will ask logistical questions, like visa status, graduation timeline, notice period etc

[Want to know exactly how to answer them based on YOUR OWN SITUATION?](#)

[Book a free call here to see how we help](#)

2. RECRUITMENT AGENCY (MIDDLEMAN)



- They aren't an employee inside the hiring company
- They are a middleman hired to just recruit candidates
- They get paid when they are able to find suitable candidates, so efficiency is important for them
- They are usually industry specialised, so they may know more technical details of the job
- The content of the call would be similar to the content with In house HR.
- List of examples: theheadstartmentoring.com/recruitment-agencies-australia



Since they only get paid full amount when the role is hired, they have an incentive to move things quick and finish the job



Be responsive, and ready to move quick.

Including offer to send them your availability right away and your keenness for the role.

You and them are on the same side → to find a suitable candidate to be hired (you)



BONUS TIPS X 3

1. For international Students

When asked about visa status, say you have unlimited work rights (if graduating soon). Don't need to mention the 2 year deadline yet until they ask for more information.

2. You have to create a chance to

Engage in small talk to ask about their day and **extend it into a normal conversation.**

Recruiters call countless people a day and **a lot of candidates just want to sell themselves** and are not interested in actually talking. This is a golden opportunity to be stand out.

3. Prepare AT LEAST 2 questions to ask the recruiters, here is what you can ask:

- Company culture*
- Interview/Recruiting timeline

Bonus tip*: Instead of asking 'What is the company culture' - ask 'What is your experience in the company and it's culture' → Now you asking about how **THEY FEEL** about the company, instead of just about the company

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN SCREENING CALL/ONLINE INTERVIEW VS IN PERSON INTERVIEW

- The core difference is the **existence of human connection**
- To build human connection, be personable and engage in small talk as much as possible
- Recruiters make 20+ calls a day hearing pitches, so actually wanting to talk to them (not just pitch) helps you stand out

How to always make sure there is small talk?

Prepare prepare prepare!

Think:

- Something you did on the weekend (if the Interview is on Monday/Tuesday)
- A hobby you did yesterday(if Interview's on Wednesday) **Bonus points if it overlaps with a hobby you spotted on the interviewer's LinkedIn**
- Something you did this morning, or on your way to the interview
- The weather, if it shifted noticeably

After sharing about yourself, always flip it back: "And how about you?" or "How's your week been?" It gives them a chance to talk and builds rapport before the real questions start.

TO ADVANCE TO THE NEXT STAGE, YOU HAVE TO:

1. Understand the difference of a screening call/online interview vs an In-person interview
2. Progressed 2+ times to the next round from them screening calls
3. You are able to cater your communication depending who you are talking to (HR inside company vs middleman recruiter)

P.S.

Tired of wasting golden opportunities on screening calls?
We can help you practise and improve

 **SECURE A SPOT FOR MENTORSHIP WITH US,**
BEFORE YOUR COMPETITOR FINDS US! 

TO BUILD THE FOUNDATION, YOU MUST AT LEAST **ACHIEVE 3 OUT OF 6** OF THE FOLLOWING FEATURES OF A STRONG CANDIDATE

Based on:

- Conversations with 500+ students/grads
- 30+ offers secured across Tech/Business/Engineering

1. Relevant Internship Experience



- Local internship preferred; one from home country also works, as it builds employer confidence you can do the job
- This is the "**juice**" to your resume/LinkedIn
- Virtual internships (e.g. Forage) don't count as valid internship experience to most hirers

2. Society Executive Role



- Being an Executive = leading a function of the society, sometimes managing sub-committees
- Gives you "real world experience" distinct from internships

3. 85+ WAM / Relevant Professional Certificates / Wins in Case Competitions



- Grades matter only above 85+
- A relevant, widely recognized certificate (e.g. CFA for Finance, CISSP for Cyber Security) makes a difference
- Case comp wins count if top 3 or similarly notable

4. Relevant Passion Project



- Showcases proactivity and interest in the field
- Must have **direct impact** on your daily life or social circle, **preferably quantifiable**
- AI can help execute the project, but *direct impact is non-negotiable*

5. Unique Personal Story / Fun Facts



- Everyone has unique stories
- Unique stories make you memorable among hundreds of applicants
- 1-2 relevant fun facts about yourself can help you stand out immediately

6. Australia Job Experience (can be casual roles/volunteering)



- Local experience is **KING**, it shows you can communicate with people in Australia
- Casual or part-time work reassures employers on communication skills
- No job? Volunteering works too, if done consistently (e.g. once every 2 weeks)

I DON'T HAVE 3 OUT OF 6 WHAT DO I DO?



We understand all features are not easy to obtain in a short period of time, especially for society exec roles, internships, 85+ WAM. **However, don't be discouraged as there are 3 things we can start TODAY!**

Unique Personal Story / Fun Facts



Fun fact: You already have them. You just need a third opinion to validate and point out these unique stories. Here is a practical step by step on how to extract them.

1. Write down every single memorable activity you have done since High School to Today
2. Write down your target field (ie marketing / accounting / software engineer)
3. List out 2 memorable incidents per activity, that is related to your target field
4. Find a person that is already inside the industry / have an internship at least
5. Present your timeline to them to ask them to highlight what is interesting about yourself (If you cannot find that person - [we can help you](#))

Time Required: 2-4 hours

Where can you utilise these unique stories:

- LinkedIn 'abouts' page
- Resume professional profile
- Interview answers



Relevant Passion Project

Please understand your passion project should not be 'Generic AI Slop'.

Here are some idea avenues that are accepted across every field:

- Non-assignment related academic researches
- Technical tools that enhances your life / life of your social circle (ie A finance tracker)
- Blogs / Articles posted regularly
- Business Ideas to make money (has to be related to your field, or a part of business that has to use your particular skills in your field)

Time Required: 3-4 weeks

Where can you utilise these unique stories:

- LinkedIn + Resume Experiences
- Interview answers

Key to a successful passion project:



1. **Must generate an impact/results**, ie:

- saved \$ amount of money
- got x amount of user
- got x amount of likes of a social media post
- made x amount of money
- got recognition from professor

2. **You must have worked a combined of 20+ hours towards the passion project.**

When you work hard towards a project, you'd actually gain the confidence in your hard work, and this confidence is the **difference maker, especially during interview stages. Trust us, we have talked to 600+ mentees, recruiters, managers - and everyone can easily tell if your passion project is some 'AI slop' or the real deal.**

Want to make sure your passion project actually contributes to you being a strong candidate? [We provide real expertise from industry professionals that made it because of passion projects, through 1v1 mentorship.](#)

Australia Job Experience (can be casual / part time roles / volunteering)

Casual / Part time roles



How to get a casual / part time job, 3 ways, ranged from Easiest to Hardest:

1. Text every single friend of yours in Australia if their part time work place has any vacancies
2. Online applications
3. Print a resume of your past casual job history, go to the suburbs near you, walk in every shop and introduce yourself + ask if you can hand a resume to the manager

To understand deeper the difference between casual job applications, or what to include in a casual job resume. [Book a free call here](#) so we connect you to a mentor who previously did a part time job.

Time Required: 4-8 weeks

Where can you utilise this experience:

- LinkedIn + Resume Experiences
- Interview answers

Volunteering

To find volunteering activities that are available, insert this prompt to your LLM of choice:

Context: I live in [Insert suburb and state]. I'm building a candidacy for [Insert field].

Task: Find 5 volunteer opportunities that could strengthen this candidacy.

Criteria (all must apply):

- In or related to [Insert field]
- Involves teamwork: regular interaction/collaboration with other volunteers, not solo work
- Easy to get accepted (minimal vetting/interview process)
- Can start within 1 month from today
- Ongoing/regular commitment (not a one-off event)

Output format per option:

- Name + hyperlink
- 1-2 sentence description
- Acceptance difficulty rating (Easy / Medium / Hard, with a one-line reason why)